

Boston Swaps Flock Safety for New License Plate Readers

A report outlines how Boston police launched pilots with Motorola and Axon as replacement platforms, which raised new questions about compliance with a city council ordinance.

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(TNS) — Flock Safety cameras will no longer monitor drivers in Boston. But that doesn't mean Boston police are backing away from license plate reader technology.

After [an annual surveillance report](#) this week revealed [Flock improperly shared Boston vehicle data](#) with outside law enforcement agencies just three days into the pilot program, Mayor Michelle Wu said the city had “abandoned” the system. The Flock pilot involved roughly 45 automated license plate recognition (ALPR) cameras from April 1 through Sept. 4, 2025.

Yet the report outlines how Boston police already launched pilot programs with Motorola and

Axon as replacement ALPR platforms, which raised new questions about compliance with a city council ordinance that requires approval for new surveillance technologies.

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The launch of these short-term pilot programs includes 45 Motorola ALPR cameras that started in February and about 30 Axon ALPR cameras that began June 1.

Those previously undisclosed trials quickly became a focal point for critics, who argue the testing itself undermines the city's surveillance oversight process.

Boston police defy surveillance ordinance, councilor says

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In the hours after news broke of Flock's contract breach, Boston City Councilor At-Large Julia M. Mejia warned the incident underscored broader concerns with all surveillance technology used in Boston — particularly the continued testing of new systems without city council approval.

"This is exactly why people lose trust in government," Mejia said.

"We bypassed the public process our communities deserve and then handed their data to a private company that failed to keep it secure. The safeguards we fought to put in place exist precisely to prevent situations like this," she said.

What concerned Mejia even more than the Flock data-sharing lapse itself was the police department's continued testing of surveillance technologies without prior city council approval.

Mejia argued the continued pilot programs contradict the purpose of the city's 2021 surveillance ordinance, which requires council approval before city departments — including the police — can acquire or use surveillance technology like facial recognition, license plate readers and video networks.

day before news of Flock's breach broke, Wu went on GBH for a Sunday interview and supported the use of ALPR technology with appropriate guardrails, such as "authorized

policy” in place to guarantee protections of privacy and civil liberty.

The purpose of ALPR is “to be able to keep people safe — to solve crimes faster and to ensure that we are doing things as efficiently as we can,” Wu said.

A joint statement from Boston police and Wu’s office on Monday stated that even since Boston ended all use of Flock due to the contract violation, the city’s “use of technology to advance the safety and wellbeing of residents must also protect privacy rights and civil liberties, safeguarding the community trust that helps make Boston the safest major city in the country.”

The ALPR system was established in Boston through a Boston police special order in October 2016 with cameras from a company called **3M — a large global enterprise** known for science, industrial goods and safety products that manufactured tolling cameras, along with ALPR technology and software.

The **3M enterprise sold off its entire tolling and ALPR hardware** and software business in 2017 and Boston police stated all ALPR 3M legacy cameras in the city are now defunct.

Mejia said she has opposed surveillance technology used by city police for years, including Flock and other cell-site simulators — technology used by law enforcement that appear as cell phone towers so that nearby phones connect to it, which allow officers see which phones are in the area and track a specific phone’s location.

She also cited her office’s challenges against the Boston Regional Intelligence Center (BRIC), an intelligence-sharing fusion center that’s managed by the Boston Police Department to coordinate local, state and federal law enforcement agencies.

Mejia says these tools “put the wellbeing and privacy of Bostonians at risk, particularly immigrants and people of color.”

Even as the city has backed away from Flock, Boston police are conducting trials under apparent little oversight with companies that provide essentially the same services — and raise the very same privacy concerns.

Boston abandoned Flock. It didn’t abandon surveillance

Maria Villegas Bravo, counsel at the nonprofit Electronic Privacy Information Center (EPIC), said replacing Flock with another vendor does little to address the underlying privacy concerns.

There are “no meaningful differences” between the ALPR capabilities of Axon, Motorola and Flock, according to Villegas Bravo.

While each company promotes different features and cybersecurity safeguards, “the main issue is that they all do the same thing, essentially” — collecting vehicle information and enabling that data to be shared through broader law-enforcement networks, she said.

On its site, **Flock** advertises a nationwide, 49-state network and AI-powered searches that can identify vehicles based on characteristics beyond a license plate.

Axon's platform combines vehicle recognition cameras with live video, real-time alerts, third-party camera integrations and expanding AI tools. **Motorola** similarly offers vehicle searches based on details such as make, model, color, damage and bumper stickers, emphasizing agency control over data retention and sharing.

“Any sort of tool that has the potential for mass surveillance has no place being promoted as a public safety tool and actually endangers us overall more than it helps,” said Reem Suleiman, senior campaign director at Fight for the Future.

“It’s also not just about Flock ... there will always be a new Flock, and there are ‘Flocks’ under the hood, in many city departments that people have absolutely no awareness of,” Suleiman said.

The annual report suggests that concern extends far beyond the Flock program. However, Sen. Nick Collins said, in response to inquiry of the Flock breach in Boston, that pilot programs “are made to test and get the kinks out of a new practice.”

“I believe technology should be used to help make us more efficient and safer. But there’s got to be a balance to ensure people’s rights are protected,” Collins said in a statement Monday.

“That said, nothing can nor should replace a well-trained police officer so we need to be investing more in that as well,” Collins said.

And while city officials and Boston police have said there was no unauthorized access by city officers during the brief Flock data-sharing lapse, departments across Massachusetts have abandoned the technology over a range of concerns, from privacy and oversight questions to allegations of misuse.

In Weymouth, officials opted not to renew the town’s contract after learning of previously disclosed AI features, while investigations into suspected misuse by officers in Stow, New

Bedford and Lynn have intensified scrutiny statewide.

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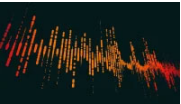
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